

A FRAMEWORK IN CHAPTERS

Chapter Sixteen

Meritism

*The Significant · attention as social
licence and exemption from rules*

Meritism is the system in which demonstrated capacity to capture collective attention and fascination grants social licence and exemption from ordinary rules. This chapter runs it through the five domains — from the Nollywood star to the social media influencer to the slow death of the ordinary person whose self-worth is measured by their following.

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CHAPTER 16 OF AN ONGOING FRAMEWORK

Meritism

Meritism is the fifteenth Fundamental Matrix. The framework’s outline names it as the system in which demonstrated capacity to capture collective attention and fascination grants social licence and exemption from ordinary rules. The matrix is called Meritism because the ‘merit’ in question is not moral or intellectual achievement but the capacity to be seen — to capture and hold the collective gaze.

Meritism overlaps with Productivism (Chapter 8, which enforces productivity) and with Rankism (Chapter 2, which ranks by position). But the three matrices are not the same. Productivism ranks by productivity. Rankism ranks by position. Meritism ranks by significance — the capacity to capture and hold collective attention. The framework separates them so that the attention-capture logic specifically can be studied and dismantled.

A note on method. The Interpersonal, Disciplinary, and Structural sections take the naive approach — each triad described as if happening for the first time, with no networks, residues, or Canon referenced. The Hegemonic Domain section is where Canon and Practice finally enter the picture.

READING NOTE

Same convention as Chapters 1 through 15. Every paragraph is written to be tweetable. Where you see literal blanks (____), the framework is asking you to write yourself into it. This chapter’s blanks may be uncomfortable: every Nigerian who has compared their follower count to someone else’s, who has felt the pull of going viral, or who has given a celebrity a pass they would not give an ordinary person, has been inside this matrix.

Contents

Meritism	1
Contents	1
1. Definition: What Meritism Extracts, Enforces, and Removes	3
1.1 What Meritism Extracts	3
1.2 What Meritism Enforces	4
1.3 What Options Meritism Removes	4
2. The Interpersonal Domain	5
3.1 Enforcement Triad: Celebrity as Exception Standard	5

3.2 Enforcement Triad: Influencer as Authority Standard	5
3.3 Enforcement Triad: Attention Economy as Only Economy Standard	6
3.4 Enforcement Triad: Follower Count as Social Currency Standard	6
3.5 Extraction Triad: Ordinary Person's Attention	7
3.6 Extraction Triad: Ordinary Person's Deference	7
3.7 Extraction Triad: Ordinary Person's Self-Worth	7
3.8 Extraction Triad: Significant Person's Privacy and Authenticity	8
3. The Disciplinary Domain	10
4.1 Disciplinary Hierarchy — Nested Stars	10
4.2 Disciplinary Community — Distributed Network	10
4. The Structural Domain	12
5.1 Bureaucracy — Enduring Rules and Procedures	12
5.2 Stratification — Enduring Zero-Sum Rankings	12
5.3 Classification — Enduring Categorical Divisions	13
5. The Hegemonic Domain: The Ascension Ritual	14
6.1 Canon — Rewriting History	14
6.2 Practice — Rewriting Reality	15
6. When Did Meritism Rewrite History?	17
7. Fill in the Blank: A Self-Examination	17
Question 1: When did Meritism rewrite your reality?	17
Question 2: How is Meritism causing your Death?	18
8. Endnotes & References	19
Coming Next	20

SECTION 1

1. Definition: What Meritism Extracts, Enforces, and Removes

Meritism is the system in which demonstrated capacity to capture collective attention and fascination grants social licence and exemption from ordinary rules. The theoretical foundations draw on Guy Debord's *The Society of the Spectacle* (1967), which argued that under modern capitalism, social life is mediated by images, and the spectacle replaces genuine social interaction with the passive consumption of representations.

Daniel Boorstin's *The Image* (1961) coined the term 'pseudo-event' — an event staged primarily for the purpose of being reported. Neil Postman's *Amusing Ourselves to Death* (1985) showed how the medium of television had reduced all public discourse to entertainment. Jean Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981) showed how the image had replaced the real, so that the celebrity is not a person but a simulation of a person.

Joshua Gamson's *Claims to Fame* (1994) and Chris Rojek's *Celebrity* (2001) supplied the contemporary celebrity studies framework. Alice Marwick's *Status Update* (2013) extended the analysis to social media, showing how the attention economy has democratised the pursuit of significance while concentrating the rewards. Byung-Chul Han's *Psychopolitics* (2017) showed how digital power operates through the subject's own desire for visibility.

For the Nigerian context, the Nollywood scholarship of Jonathan Haynes, Onookome Okome, and Brian Larkin supplies the analysis of the Nigerian star system. The Afrobeats global explosion, from the 2010s, has produced a new generation of Nigerian celebrities whose significance is measured in global streams, global followers, and global attention. The Pentecostal megachurch pastor as celebrity — with private jets, mansion, and millions of followers — is a specifically Nigerian expression of Meritism at the intersection of religion and spectacle.

1.1 What Meritism Extracts

Meritism extracts five things. First, **the ordinary person's attention**: the cognitive resource the ordinary person directs at the significant, consuming their content, following their life, discussing their actions. Attention is finite; Meritism channels it to the few at the expense of the many. Second, **the ordinary person's deference**: the social submission the ordinary person performs toward the significant, treating their opinions as more valuable, their preferences as more important, their time as more precious.

Third, **the ordinary person's resources**: the money channeled to the significant through ticket sales, merchandise, subscriptions, endorsements, and the consumer economy that the celebrity drives.

Fourth, **the ordinary person's self-worth**: the comparison the ordinary person performs between

their own life and the celebrity's curated image, finding themselves wanting.

Fifth, **the significant person's privacy and authenticity**: the extraction is not only from the ordinary to the significant. The significant person loses their privacy to the public gaze and their authenticity to the performance of significance. The celebrity who cannot leave their house without being photographed, who cannot express an opinion without it being amplified, who cannot age without it being commented on — each has lost privacy and authenticity to the spectacle.

1.2 What Meritism Enforces

Meritism enforces four standards. First, the **celebrity as exception**: the assumption that the significant person is exempt from rules that bind the ordinary. The celebrity who skips the queue. The celebrity who receives the VIP treatment. The celebrity who is not prosecuted for the offence that would imprison the ordinary person.

Second, the **influencer as authority**: the assumption that the capacity to capture attention confers authority on subjects the influencer is not qualified to address. The influencer who endorses the health product without medical training. The celebrity who opines on policy without expertise. The significant person whose platform is treated as expertise.

Third, the **attention economy as the only economy**: the assumption that value is measured by attention, that the viral is the valuable, that the trending is the important. Fourth, the **follower count as social currency**: the assumption that the number of followers measures the worth of the person, and that the person with more followers is more valuable than the person with fewer.

1.3 What Options Meritism Removes

Concretely, Meritism removes the option of being ordinary without social cost. The person who has no following, no public presence, no viral moment is treated as insignificant — not as a full person who has chosen obscurity, but as a failed significant who has not yet achieved visibility.

It removes the option of anonymity. The assumption that everyone should be findable, that everyone should have a social media presence, that everyone should be 'discoverable.' The person who refuses to be online is treated as suspicious or eccentric. It removes the option of refusing attention. The person who does not want to be seen, who does not want their photo taken, who does not want their life curated for an audience, is treated as anti-social.

It removes the option of equal treatment. The ordinary person who is denied the VIP treatment that the celebrity receives is told, directly or indirectly, that their ordinariness is the reason for the denial. It removes the option of a self not defined by audience. The person whose self-worth is independent of their following, whose identity is not mediated by the platform, whose value is not measured by engagement metrics — that person is treated as not yet arrived at the modern condition. Each removal is enforced by the media, by the market, by the platform, and by the triads below.

SECTION 2 · NAIVE APPROACH

2. The Interpersonal Domain

The Interpersonal Domain contains four enforcement triads and four extraction triads. Each is described here as if happening for the first time — no networks, no residues, no Canon.

3.1 Enforcement Triad: Celebrity as Exception Standard

The enforcer is the person or institution that grants the significant person exemption from ordinary rules. The restaurant that gives the celebrity the best table. The police officer who lets the celebrity go without the ticket. The court that gives the celebrity the lighter sentence. The airport that gives the celebrity the VIP lounge. The enforcement is performed by the special treatment, by the waived rule, by the reduced sentence, or by the exclusive access.

The subject conforms by accepting the exemption or by deferring to the exempted. The conforming act is the acceptance itself — the ordinary person watches the celebrity receive the special treatment and does not object, because the special treatment is treated as the natural consequence of significance.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The ordinary person who is denied the VIP treatment loses the option to equal treatment, which is to say, loses the option to dignity. The ordinary person who watches the celebrity receive the lighter sentence loses the option to equal justice, which is to say, loses the option to the rule of law.

The witness is the person who watches the exemption and says nothing, or who themselves grant exemptions to their own significant acquaintances. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the institution that profits from the celebrity's presence — the restaurant that gains publicity from the celebrity's visit — without personally commanding the exemption.

3.2 Enforcement Triad: Influencer as Authority Standard

The enforcer is the person or institution that treats the influencer's attention-capture capacity as expertise. The brand that hires the influencer to endorse the product. The media that invites the influencer to comment on the issue. The university that invites the celebrity to give the commencement address. The enforcement is performed by the hire, by the invitation, by the platform, or by the amplification.

The subject conforms by treating the influencer as authority. The conforming act is the acceptance itself — the ordinary person buys the endorsed product, listens to the celebrity's opinion, attends the commencement. The subject does not ask whether the influencer is qualified, because the qualification is the following.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The ordinary person who buys the influencer-endorsed product loses the option to accurate information, which is to say, loses the option to informed choice. The ordinary person who listens to the celebrity's opinion on policy loses the option to expert analysis. The expert who is not a celebrity loses the option to being heard, because the platform goes to the significant, not to the qualified.

The witness is the person who watches the influencer-as-authority enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves amplify the influencer's opinion. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the brand that profits from the endorsement without personally commanding the authority.

3.3 Enforcement Triad: Attention Economy as Only Economy Standard

The enforcer is the platform or institution that requires value be measured by attention. The social media platform that ranks by engagement. The news outlet that ranks by clicks. The advertising market that prices by reach. The employer that requires the personal brand. The enforcement is performed by the algorithm, by the metric, by the price, or by the employment requirement.

The subject conforms by performing for attention. The conforming act is the performance itself — the subject creates the content, cultivates the following, seeks the viral moment, and measures their worth by the engagement. The subject who does not perform for attention is treated as not yet arrived at the modern condition.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The person who would rather create without an audience loses the option to unmonetised creation, which is to say, loses the option to a self not defined by metrics. The person who would rather work without a personal brand loses the option to professional identity without performance. The person who does not want to be seen loses the option to obscurity.

The witness is the person who watches the attention-economy enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves perform for attention. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the platform that profits from the engagement without personally commanding the performance.

3.4 Enforcement Triad: Follower Count as Social Currency Standard

The enforcer is the person or institution that ranks by follower count. The brand that pays the influencer by reach. The event that invites the speaker by following. The social circle that ranks the member by their online presence. The enforcement is performed by the payment, by the invitation, by the ranking, or by the social treatment.

The subject conforms by cultivating the following. The conforming act is the cultivation itself — the subject posts, engages, follows back, and tracks the number. The subject who has few followers is treated as insignificant, regardless of their actual qualities.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The person with few followers loses the option to equal credibility, which is to say, loses the option to being taken seriously regardless of audience. The person who would rather not cultivate a following loses the option to professional opportunities that require a

platform.

The witness is the person who watches the follower-count enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves rank by following. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the platform that profits from the follower-cultivation without personally commanding the ranking.

3.5 Extraction Triad: Ordinary Person's Attention

The extractor is the significant person or platform that requires the ordinary person's attention. The celebrity who requires the fan's consumption. The influencer who requires the follower's engagement. The platform that requires the user's scroll. The extraction is performed by the content, by the algorithm, by the notification, or by the social pressure to be informed.

The subject conforms by attending. What is extracted is the attention itself — the finite cognitive resource the ordinary person directs at the significant. The extraction is invisible because it is performed as 'entertainment' or 'staying informed.'

The options the subject loses are concrete. The ordinary person who spends hours scrolling loses the option to that time, which is to say, loses the option to the activities that the scroll displaced. The ordinary person whose attention is captured by the significant loses the option to attention for their own life, their own relationships, their own community.

The witness is the person who watches the attention extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves consume the significant's content. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the advertiser who profits from the attention without personally commanding the extraction.

3.6 Extraction Triad: Ordinary Person's Deference

The extractor is the significant person who requires the ordinary person's deference. The celebrity who expects the fan's adulation. The influencer who expects the follower's agreement. The significant person who expects the ordinary person's accommodation. The extraction is performed by the expectation, by the social pressure, or by the explicit demand.

The subject conforms by deferring. What is extracted is the deference itself — the social submission the ordinary person performs toward the significant. The extraction is invisible because it is performed as 'admiration' or 'respect.'

The options the subject loses are concrete. The fan who defers to the celebrity loses the option to critical judgment, which is to say, loses the option to evaluating the celebrity's work on its merits. The follower who defers to the influencer loses the option to independent opinion.

The witness is the person who watches the deference extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves defer to the significant. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the significant person's entourage who benefits from the reflected deference without personally commanding it.

3.7 Extraction Triad: Ordinary Person's Self-Worth

The extractor is the attention economy that requires the ordinary person compare themselves to the significant. The curated Instagram feed that presents the celebrity's perfect life. The viral video that presents the influencer's effortless success. The award show that presents the star's glamorous existence. The extraction is performed by the image, by the comparison, by the algorithm, or by the social pressure to measure up.

The subject conforms by comparing. What is extracted is the self-worth itself — the ordinary person's confidence in their own life, their own achievements, their own body, their own relationships. The extraction transfers the self-worth to the significant, with the ordinary person left to feel inadequate.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The ordinary person who compares their life to the celebrity's curated image loses the option to self-acceptance, which is to say, loses the option to a self that is not measured by the significant's standard. The ordinary person who internalises the comparison loses the option to mental health, because the comparison always favours the curated over the real.

The witness is the person who watches the self-worth extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves compare. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the advertiser who profits from the insecurity — the beauty product that promises to close the gap between the ordinary and the significant — without personally commanding the extraction.

3.8 Extraction Triad: Significant Person's Privacy and Authenticity

The extractor is the public that requires the significant person's privacy and authenticity be sacrificed. The paparazzi who photographs the celebrity's private moment. The fan who approaches the celebrity in public. The social media that amplifies the celebrity's every word. The award show that requires the celebrity perform gratitude. The extraction is performed by the photograph, by the approach, by the amplification, or by the performance requirement.

The subject conforms by performing. What is extracted is the privacy and authenticity itself — the significant person's right to a private life, to an unperformed self, to a moment without an audience. The extraction transfers the privacy to the public, with the significant person reduced to a public performance.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The celebrity who cannot leave their house without being photographed loses the option to privacy, which is to say, loses the option to a self that is not performed. The celebrity who cannot express an opinion without it being amplified loses the option to authenticity, which is to say, loses the option to a self that is not curated. The extraction is the cost of significance — the price the significant pays for the attention they have captured.

The witness is the person who watches the privacy extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves consume the significant's private moments. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the media outlet that profits from the privacy extraction without personally commanding it.

Nascent forms of this system include: ‘Do you know who I am?’, ‘Don’t you know who that is?’, ‘My following is bigger than yours’, ‘I have X thousand followers’, ‘Going viral’, ‘Trending’, ‘Clout’, ‘Clout chasing’, ‘Influencer’, ‘Brand ambassador’, ‘Celebrity endorsement’, ‘VIP’, ‘Exclusive’, ‘Red carpet’, ‘The green room’, ‘Meet and greet’, ‘Fan’, ‘Parasocial relationship’, ‘Verified’, ‘Sponsored post’, ‘The A-list’, ‘Has-been’, ‘15 minutes of fame’, ‘The spotlight’, ‘Views’, ‘The algorithm’.

SECTION 3 · NAIVE APPROACH

3. The Disciplinary Domain

When the eight triads above link into networks, Meritism scales. Both hierarchical and community-based forms are visible in every Nigerian institution that organises significance.

4.1 Disciplinary Hierarchy — Nested Stars

Peak Triad-Node

At the peak is the triad where the highest significance authority enforces on the layer below. In the entertainment industry, the peak is the award show producer and the platform algorithm, which together determine who is seen and who is not. In the social media hierarchy, the peak is the platform itself — the algorithm that determines reach, the verification system that determines credibility, the monetisation system that determines income. In the religious celebrity hierarchy, the peak is the megachurch General Overseer with millions of followers. In the political celebrity hierarchy, the peak is the President, whose every statement is amplified by the media.

Middle Triad-Nodes

The middle nodes are where the chain's character is clearest. The A-list star who defers to the award show producer in the morning demands deference from the B-list star in the afternoon. The verified influencer who defers to the platform in the morning demands deference from the micro-influencer in the afternoon. The senior pastor who defers to the General Overseer in the morning demands deference from the parish pastor in the afternoon.

The middle is where Meritism reproduces. The fan who becomes a micro-influencer enforces significance on their own followers. The upcoming artist who becomes a star enforces significance on their own fans. The middle position teaches the subject to pursue significance and to enforce the hierarchy of significance on those below.

Bottom Triad-Node

At the bottom is the ordinary person — the person with no following, no public presence, no viral moment. The ordinary person is the fan, the follower, the consumer, the audience. The ordinary person is the one whose attention is extracted, whose deference is extracted, whose self-worth is extracted. The bottom is where the system's extraction is most concentrated, because the ordinary person is the one who pays for the significance of the few with the attention, deference, and self-worth of the many.

4.2 Disciplinary Community — Distributed Network

A Disciplinary Community is a distributed network. The witness of one Meritism triad becomes the enforcer of another. Meritism spreads laterally through any person who has witnessed the enforcement

of significance without dissenting.

The Fandom Networks

The fandom networks circulate Meritism laterally across the Nigerian youth. The fan club that organises around the celebrity. The stan account that defends the celebrity against criticism. The group chat that shares the celebrity's latest post. The networks reproduce the ordinary-person's-deference and ordinary-person's-attention triads across the fandom.

The Social Media Engagement Networks

The social media engagement networks circulate Meritism laterally across the digital public. The like, the comment, the share, the retweet — each is an act of attention that feeds the algorithm, which feeds the significance. The networks reproduce the attention-economy-as-only-economy triad across the digital public.

The Celebrity Gossip Networks

The celebrity gossip networks circulate Meritism laterally across the Nigerian media ecosystem. The blog that reports the celebrity's every move. The podcast that analyses the celebrity's every word. The WhatsApp group that shares the celebrity's latest scandal. The networks reproduce the significant-person's-privacy extraction triad across the media.

The Award Culture Networks

The award culture networks circulate Meritism laterally across the Nigerian entertainment industry. The Headies, the AMVCA, the City People Awards — each is a ceremony that ranks the significant by degree of significance. The networks reproduce the follower-count-as-social-currency triad across the industry.

The Endorsement Economy Networks

The endorsement economy networks circulate Meritism laterally across the Nigerian consumer market. The brand that hires the celebrity. The agency that brokers the deal. The consumer who buys the endorsed product. The networks reproduce the influencer-as-authority triad across the market.

SECTION 4 · NAIVE APPROACH

4. The Structural Domain

Run the Ship of Theseus test. When the original celebrities and original influencers are replaced, when the platforms are redesigned, what is consistent? What outlives both individuals and platforms? What forces new Nigerians to re-form into the same patterns — not because anyone instructs them to, but because the residue makes any other pattern costly or invisible?

Meritism leaves all three residues. Almost every Nigerian institution carries Bureaucracy, Stratification, and Classification from Meritism simultaneously.

5.1 Bureaucracy — Enduring Rules and Procedures

Meritism's bureaucracy is the codified significance structure. The Nigerian Copyright Act protects celebrity intellectual property — the celebrity's image, name, and likeness as marketable assets. The NAFDAC regulation of celebrity-endorsed products is minimal, allowing the celebrity to endorse products with little accountability for the product's safety. The APCON code on advertising with celebrities is similarly minimal.

The CAC registration of celebrity brands codifies the celebrity's significance as corporate identity. The award industry — the Headies, the AMVCA, the City People Awards — functions as a bureaucracy that ranks and certifies significance. The social media platform's terms of service function as the regulatory framework for the attention economy, with the platform as the unelected regulator.

The influencer marketing industry's self-regulation (or lack thereof) allows the industry to operate without effective consumer protection. The VIP culture in public institutions — VIP lounges at airports, VIP seating at events, VIP lanes at checkpoints — codifies the celebrity exception into the built environment. The protocol system in government gives celebrities and significant persons special access to public officials that ordinary citizens do not receive.

5.2 Stratification — Enduring Zero-Sum Rankings

Meritism's stratification is the daily experience of significance rank in every institutional encounter. **Significant/insignificant** — the significant person ranks above the insignificant in social standing, in access, in media representation. **Celebrity/ordinary** — the celebrity ranks above the ordinary in every domain of public life.

Verified/unverified — the verified account ranks above the unverified in algorithmic privilege and social credibility. **A-list/D-list** — the A-list ranks above the D-list in pay, in access, and in social standing. **Viral/obscure** — the viral content ranks above the obscure in reach and value.

Trending/forgotten — the trending topic ranks above the forgotten in attention and importance.

Influential/follower — the influential ranks above the follower in authority and credibility.

5.3 Classification — Enduring Categorical Divisions

Meritism's classification is the set of categorical names that organise every Nigerian into significance categories. **Celebrity** and **ordinary** — the universal pair, with celebrity as the aspiration and ordinary as the default. **Significant** and **insignificant** — the same pair in different language.

Verified and **unverified** — the platform pair, with verified as the credentialled and unverified as the suspect. **Public figure** and **private citizen** — the legal pair, with public figure as the accountable and private citizen as the protected. **Influencer** and **consumer** — the market pair, with influencer as the producer and consumer as the recipient. **Star** and **fan** — the entertainment pair, with star as the performer and fan as the audience.

Brand and **audience** — the commercial pair, with brand as the marketer and audience as the target. **Viral** and **obscure** — the attention pair, with viral as the seen and obscure as the unseen. **Trending** and **forgotten** — the temporal pair, with trending as the current and forgotten as the past. The classification does the work before any individual enforcer shows up. A person walking into a Nigerian social event is already classified by their public presence — the verified guest is treated differently from the unverified guest.

SECTION 5

5. The Hegemonic Domain: The Ascension Ritual

Is Meritism ascended? Yes on all three counts. It produces all three structural residues including Stratification (so Internalised Domination applies). It has working Canon and Practice mechanisms. The vast majority of Nigerians cannot imagine a society where significance is not the measure of worth, where the celebrity is not the exception, where the follower count is not the currency — despite the fact that celebrity is a 20th-century invention and the influencer is a 2010s invention.

6.1 Canon — Rewriting History

Canon is the present belief that significance has always been the measure of worth. The origination of the structural residues — the star system, the award industry, the social media platform — has been forgotten. The average Nigerian now takes the celebrity, the influencer, and the follower count as natural, eternal, and without alternative.

What is forgotten? Celebrity is a 20th-century mass-media invention, not an eternal human condition. The ‘star system’ was invented by Hollywood in the 1910s, when film studios began promoting actors by name rather than by type. Before the star system, performers were anonymous. The celebrity as a social category is barely a century old. The influencer is a 2010s social media invention, barely a decade old.

Also forgotten: that pre-colonial Nigerian societies valued communal contribution over individual fame. The Yoruba proverb ‘we are, because I am, and I am, because we are’ expresses a communal ontology in which the individual is constituted by the community, not by the audience. The Igbo proverb ‘it takes a village’ expresses the same. The colonial encounter introduced the individual as the unit of significance, and the Canon now presents it as natural.

Also forgotten: that the attention economy is a recent capitalist formation. The monetisation of attention through advertising is a 20th-century development. The monetisation of attention through social media engagement is a 2010s development. The Canon presents the attention economy as the natural economy; the history shows it as a recent imposition.

Internalised Domination

Canon produces Internalised Domination because Meritism produces Stratification. The celebrity’s entitlement to deference is now natural, automatic, unquestionable. The celebrity who skips the queue does not experience this as privilege. They experience it as the natural order of significance. The influencer’s entitlement to free products is natural. The significant person’s entitlement to skip rules is natural. The famous person’s entitlement to a platform is natural. Each entitlement grows with the following.

Internalised Authority

Canon produces Internalised Authority in the Meritism enforcer regardless of personal material gain. The right to demand VIP treatment. The right to be heard above others. The right to endorse and have the endorsement treated as authority. The right to cancel and be uncancellable. Each is performed by ordinary Nigerians daily — the fan who defends the celebrity against criticism, the follower who buys the endorsed product, the event organiser who gives the celebrity the best seat. The right to enforce feels natural, automatic, and legitimate.

Internalised Oppression

Canon produces Internalised Oppression in the ordinary person and the aspiring significant person. The ordinary person who believes they are insignificant. The ordinary person who believes their worth is measured by their following. The ordinary person who compares themselves to the celebrity and finds themselves wanting. The aspiring significant person who believes they must go viral to matter. The teaching is silent; it is in the air.

The deepest form of this is the subject who has absorbed Meritism so thoroughly that they enforce it on themselves. The ordinary person who says ‘I am nobody’ because they have no following. The aspiring significant person who says ‘I need to go viral’ to explain why they perform for the algorithm. The consumer who says ‘they must know what they’re talking about’ to explain why they buy the endorsed product. The rebellion-capable subject has become the self-policing subject.

6.2 Practice — Rewriting Reality

Practice is the second mechanism of the Ascension Ritual. The interpersonal triad is repeated, again and again, until it becomes habit. The significant person forgets they can choose not to perform significance. The ordinary person forgets they can refuse the attention economy. The witness forgets they can dissent. Pierre Bourdieu called this *habitus* — the sediment of repeated practice in the body.

Byung-Chul Han, in *Psychopolitics* (2017), showed how digital power operates through the subject’s own desire for visibility — the subject self-exploits, performing for the algorithm without any external enforcer. Guy Debord, in *The Society of the Spectacle* (1967), showed how the spectacle replaces genuine social interaction with the passive consumption of representations. The body learns. The mind stops questioning. By adulthood, the Nigerian has performed the celebrity-as-exception, influencer-as-authority, attention-economy-as-only-economy, and follower-count-as-social-currency triads so many thousands of times that the alternative — being ordinary without social cost, being anonymous without suspicion, being significant without an audience — feels like a kind of amputation. The body has been trained. Practice has rewritten reality.

Death — Fast and Slow

Practice produces Death. Fast death in Meritism is spectacular: the celebrity suicide from the pressure of maintaining significance — the star who cannot live with the gap between the curated image and the real self. The death from the celebrity-endorsed product that was unsafe — the diet pill, the skin-lightening cream, the cosmetic procedure. The death from the crowd at the celebrity event — the

stampede, the crush, the fall.

The death of the ordinary person who was denied emergency care because the celebrity was being treated first — the hospital that prioritises the VIP patient over the ordinary patient. The death from the influencer-promoted dangerous challenge — the TikTok challenge that kills the teenager who attempted it for the viral moment. Each fast death is the significance hierarchy at its most concentrated.

Slow death in Meritism is quiet. Chronic stress of maintaining significance — the celebrity who has not slept properly in years because the next post must go up, the next event must be attended, the next endorsement must be fulfilled. Mental health collapse from the parasocial relationship — the fan who has invested so much emotional energy in the celebrity that their own mental health collapses when the celebrity disappoints.

The slow erasure of the ordinary person from public visibility — the algorithm that does not surface their content, the media that does not cover their story, the platform that does not verify their account. The slow erosion of self-worth in the attention economy — the person who checks their likes and finds them wanting, who compares their following and finds it small, who scrolls through the curated feeds and finds their own life inadequate. The financial drain of the consumer economy that channels resources to the significant — the ticket prices, the merchandise, the subscription fees, the endorsed products. The cumulative damage of comparison culture — the body image anxiety, the lifestyle envy, the achievement comparison. The slow death of community as attention is captured by the few — the neighbourhood that no longer gathers because everyone is scrolling. None of these make the news. They are Meritism's quiet tax.

Ruth Wilson Gilmore's definition applies: Meritism produces group-differentiated vulnerability to premature death. The groups are the ordinary (who are erased), the aspiring significant (who are exploited), the celebrity (who is consumed), the fan (who is extracted from). The premature death is fast (celebrity suicide, unsafe product death, crowd death, denied-care death, challenge death) or slow (significance stress, parasocial collapse, erasure, self-worth erosion, financial drain, comparison damage, community death). Every ascended matrix kills. Meritism kills those whose relation to significance does not fit the attention-capture model.

SECTION 6

6. When Did Meritism Rewrite History?

The framework's historical question: when did Meritism rewrite history in popular Nigerian living memory?

Pre-colonial Nigerian societies valued communal contribution over individual fame. The Yoruba communal ontology. The Igbo village republic. The Hausa communal structure. The individual was constituted by the community, not by the audience. The exceptional person — the great hunter, the skilled craftsperson, the wise elder, the powerful warrior — was respected, but the respect was communal, not mediated by a mass audience. There was no celebrity as such, because there was no mass media to produce the celebrity.

Colonial codification introduced the mass media that produced the celebrity. The colonial newspaper. The colonial cinema. The colonial radio. Each created a mass audience that could be directed at the individual, producing the celebrity as a social category. The colonial star system in Nigerian entertainment began with the colonial-era traveling theatre and the early cinema.

Post-independence replication continued the production. Nollywood, from the 1990s, produced the Nigerian star system at scale. The Afrobeats global explosion, from the 2010s, produced the Nigerian music celebrity with a global following. The Pentecostal megachurch, from the 1970s, produced the pastor as celebrity with private jets and millions of followers. The social media platform, from the 2010s, produced the influencer as a new category of significant person.

The tipping point in popular living memory: **circa 1960s-1970s for the Nollywood and music star system; circa 2010s for the social media influencer economy**. For Nigerians born after 1960, Meritism has 'always been' in its current form. They cannot recall a time when the celebrity was not the exception, when the follower count was not the currency, when the attention economy was not the economy.

SECTION 7

7. Fill in the Blank: A Self-Examination

The framework asks two questions of every subject of every ascended matrix. The blanks are for you.

Question 1: When did Meritism rewrite your reality?

When did the system teach you that you could not rebel? The moment was: _____. The year was: _____. The person or institution who first made you feel that challenging the significance

hierarchy was impossible was: _____. The place was: _____. What you wanted to say but did not was: _____. What you did instead was: _____. What you told yourself about why you did not say it was: _____. The significance performance you assumed in that moment was: _____. What you lost, in that moment, that you have not got back since, was: _____.

Question 2: How is Meritism causing your Death?

How is the system shortening your life right now? The form of Death I am most afraid of from Meritism is (fast/slow): _____. The specific way it is happening in my body is: _____. (For example: the chronic stress of maintaining my online presence; the insomnia from years of checking my likes; the loss of self-worth from years of comparing my life to curated feeds; the breakdown I had in 20__ that I have never fully recovered from; the money I lost buying endorsed products I did not need; the time I lost scrolling through other people's lives; the community I lost because everyone is online; the celebrity I lost my critical judgment to; the influencer whose authority I accepted without question.) The matrix's name for what is happening to me is: _____. My own name for it is: _____.

If you filled in the blanks honestly, you have just located yourself inside Meritism. The next time the triad assembles — the next time the celebrity receives the exemption, the next time the influencer is treated as authority, the next time the follower count is invoked as currency — you will be able to see the system moving through you. That sight is the beginning of abolition.

SECTION 8

8. Endnotes & References

References cited inline in this chapter, in APA format. Cumulative references from Chapters 1 through 15 are also included where they recur.

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Coming Next

Chapter 17 will take up Ethnic Majoritarianism — the system that ranks the ethnic majority above ethnic minorities in a given state. The framework’s outline names it alongside Territorialism (Chapter 18) as the two matrices that combine to form the Nationalism intersection. Ethnic Majoritarianism overlaps with Coloniality (Chapter 11) at the point where colonial classification produced ethnic categories, and with Rankism (Chapter 2) at the point where ethnic rank becomes political rank. The framework separates them so that the ethnic-majority logic specifically can be studied and dismantled.

If you are reading this chapter as part of the framework in progress, the order continues: Chapter 18 is Territorialism, Chapter 19 is State Sovereignty / Statism, and then the Fundamental Matrices list concludes. After that, the Intersectional Matrices chapter follows. The pattern is now set.